

Mengnan Xu

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PhD Candidate, Public Management, Beijing Normal University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Chinese politics and governance; state capacity and organizational mobilization; development governance; China's poverty alleviation programs; AI and computational methods for social science; political economy of China; South–South cooperation and international development.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Candidate, Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy</i>	<i>Oct 2018 – current</i> Beijing, China
Master of Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy</i>	<i>Sep 2016 – Jun 2018</i> Beijing, China
Master of Science, Information Technology and Management <i>University of Texas at Austin, McCombs School of Business</i>	<i>Jul 2023 – May 2024</i> Austin, TX, USA
Bachelor of Management Science and Engineering, Management Information Systems <i>Central South University</i>	<i>Sep 2008 – Jun 2012</i> Changsha, China

Doctoral Dissertation:

The Impact of Targeted Poverty Alleviation Policies on Long-Term Development and Vulnerability to Poverty Relapse Among Rural Households: Evidence from a Quasi-Natural Experiment Using CFPS Panel Data
Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy.

PUBLICATIONS & WORKING PAPERS

Xu, Mengnan, Robert Walker, and Lichao Yang. “Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China.” *Journal of Contemporary China*, 31(136), 756–769, 2022. DOI: 10.1080/10670564.2021.2010878. (SSCI Q1; **First Author**)

Xu, Mengnan et al. “Tobacco Control Policy Evaluation in China: Evidence from Administrative Panel Data.” *BMJ Open*, 2019.

Xu, Mengnan et al. “[. The Impact of Tobacco Taxation Policy on Slim Cigarette Use and the Growing Popularity of Slim Cigarettes in China Since 2014].” *Health*, 2019.

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Organizational Ecology and Multi-Actor State Mobilization in China’s Poverty Alleviation Governance.” *Working paper, under revision*.

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Computational Methods for Large-Scale Chinese Policy Document Analysis: A Text-as-Data Approach to Governance Research.” *Working paper, in preparation*.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Technical Research Analyst

Sep 2016 – May 2018

Gates Foundation–Funded Research Initiative, Beijing Normal University

Beijing, China

- Led end-to-end coordination of multi-year research programs on development governance and public administration reform, aligning international funding requirements with academic deliverables.
- Designed and executed large-scale quantitative and qualitative data collection; performed statistical analysis using SAS, Stata, and Python to support policy recommendations.
- Built an original organizational ecology database tracking actors, resource flows, and governance logic across China's national non-profit organization, drawing on yearbooks, government reports, and policy documents.
- Applied data ETL pipelines (topic modeling, named-entity recognition, keyword co-occurrence networks) to Chinese-language policy corpora exceeding 10,000 documents.
- Translated empirical findings into policy briefs and analytical reports for program leadership and external stakeholders.
- Managed annual planning, milestone tracking, and cross-institutional coordination across government, university, and foundation partners.

Graduate Research Assistant, Public Management

Sep 2016 – Jun 2018

Beijing Normal University, School of Government

Beijing, China

- Conducted literature reviews, archival research, and comparative policy analysis on Chinese governance, state-society relations, and public administration.
- Contributed to faculty research projects examining central–local government relations and organizational reform in China.

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer / AI Engineer

Jun 2025 – Mar 2026

Apple Inc.

Austin, TX, USA

- Developed components for Apple's Intelligence platform, focusing on production-scale natural language processing pipelines and retrieval-augmented generation architectures.
- Applied large language model techniques to large-scale information processing and knowledge integration systems, gaining first-hand engineering experience with the tools now central to computational social science.

Software Engineer

Apr 2026 – Present

Applied Optical Technologies

Houston, TX, USA

- Built full-pipeline automated data monitoring and analytics system for manufacturing execution processes.
- Designed modules for large-scale data collection, cleaning, and multi-dimensional statistical analysis.

Senior Risk Analyst

Jul 2012 – Jun 2016

Agricultural Bank of China

Hengyang, China

- Extracted and analyzed large-scale financial datasets using SQL and statistical modeling to support risk management and policy analytics.
- Developed credit scoring models (logistic regression, WOE binning) that reduced default rates and

improved loan processing efficiency.

METHODOLOGICAL AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

Quantitative and Computational Methods: Regression analysis, difference-in-differences, network analysis, causal inference; Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), R, SQL, STATA/SAS.

AI and NLP for Social Science: Large language models (fine-tuning, retrieval-augmented generation, prompt engineering), topic modeling (LDA, BERTopic), named-entity recognition, text classification, word embeddings; LangChain, OpenAI API, Hugging Face, AI agentic engineering.

Data Infrastructure: AWS (S3, Lambda, SageMaker), BigQuery, MySQL, MongoDB; Git, Jupyter, Tableau, Power BI.

Research Methods: Archival and documentary analysis, qualitative case study, elite interviews, survey research.

LANGUAGES

Mandarin Chinese	Native
English	Proficient (academic writing, presentations, and publication)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.